

doc-divine-immutability

Affirms · Theology Proper › Attributes · doctrine · unanimous_lineages · confidence: high

Statement under examination

God is unchanging in His being, perfections, purposes, and promises.

Rationale

Pan-canonical lexical demonstration: Mal 3:6 יְהוָה לֹא יִגַּע (shanah H8138 qal perfect 1cs, negated): 'I the LORD do not change'. Num 23:19 (nacham H5162 hitpaal) 'not a son of man that he should change his mind'. 1 Sam 15:29 (nacham H5162 niphal, twice negated) 'the Glory of Israel will not lie nor have regret, for he is not a man, that he should have regret'. Jas 1:17 παρ' ᾧ οὐκ ἔστι παραλλαγή ἢ τροπῆς ἀποσκίασμα (parallage G3883, trope G5157) 'with whom there is no variation or shadow of turning'. Heb 13:8 αὐτός (autos G846) 'Jesus Christ the same yesterday and today and forever'. Heb 6:17-18 τὸ ἀμετάθετον τῆς βουλῆς αὐτοῦ (ametathetos G276) 'the unchangeable character of his purpose' confirmed by oath. The same canon that has God 'relenting' (nacham niphal at Gen 6:6, Ex 32:14, 1 Sam 15:11, Jonah 3:10, Jer 18:8) explicitly denies that he does so in 1 Sam 15:29 within the same chapter (v.11 affirms nacham of God, v.29 denies the same lemma of God) and in Num 23:19, forcing the accommodation reading: the relenting passages describe God's covenantal responsiveness to creaturely repentance in human terms, not change in his essence, character, or eternal purpose.

Reasoning

Verdict: God does not change in his essential being, his character, his eternal purposes, or his promises. The strongest reasons from Scripture are direct. Malachi 3:6 has God say in the first person, 'I the LORD do not change.' Numbers 23:19 says, 'God is not man, that he should lie, or a son of man, that he should change his mind.' First Samuel 15:29 says, 'the Glory of Israel will not lie or have regret, for he is not a man, that he should have regret.' James 1:17 says of God, 'with whom there is no variation or shadow due to change.' Hebrews 13:8 applies the same point to Jesus: 'the same yesterday and today and forever.' Hebrews 6:17 calls God's purpose 'unchangeable' and adds that God confirmed it by oath. The strongest counterargument inside the Bible is the set of texts where God seems to change his mind. Genesis 6:6 says the LORD was sorry that he had made humanity. Exodus 32:14 says the LORD relented from the disaster he had threatened. First Samuel 15:11 says God regretted making Saul king. Jonah 3:10 says God relented when Nineveh repented. Jeremiah 18:8 has God himself say, 'I will relent of the disaster that I had intended.' If God changes his mind, how can he also be unchanging. The Bible answers the question itself by placing 1 Samuel 15:11 and 15:29 in the same chapter. The same word for 'regret' is affirmed of God in verse 11 and explicitly denied of God in verse 29, with the reason that God is not a man. The traditional reading is that the 'relenting' passages speak of God in human terms so that humans can understand him, the way a parent speaks down to a child. God's actions really do respond to repentance and prayer, but his essence, character, and eternal plan are not threatened by that responsiveness. Jeremiah 18:7-10 spells out the principle: announced judgment was always conditional on repentance, so when God 'relents' he is acting according to his unchanging character, not changing it. The doctrine stands canonically on the strength of the negated statements about God's nature, with the help of this accommodation reading.

Denominational landscape

Historic Christianity has confessed God's immutability nearly unanimously, though the strength of the claim varies. The early fathers like Augustine taught that God is altogether unchangeable. Thomas Aquinas

devoted Summa Theologica Part 1 Question 9 to 'The Immutability of God' and argued that God is pure act without any potential for change, citing Malachi 3:6 directly. The Catholic Catechism teaches that God is eternal and unchanging. Eastern Orthodoxy in its liturgy calls God 'ever-existing and eternally the same'. Lutherans in the Augsburg Confession Article 1 confess one Divine Essence, eternal, without body, without parts, of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness. Anglicans in the 39 Articles use very similar language. The Reformed confessions, including Westminster 2.1 and the 1689 Baptist Confession 2.1, call God immutable directly. Methodists in their Articles of Religion repeat 'one living and true God, everlasting, without body or parts, of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness'. Anabaptists at Dordrecht confess one eternal almighty God. Pentecostals in the Assemblies of God statement affirm the eternally self-existent God. So all the major lineages confess immutability in some form. The in-house dispute is about how strongly to read it. Classical theists read the 'God relented' texts as accommodation and hold that God does not change in any respect. Open theists, associated with Clark Pinnock, Gregory Boyd, and John Sanders, read those texts more literally and argue that God does change his mind in response to genuinely free creaturely choices, while still confessing that God's essential character and saving purpose do not change. Classical theists and most Reformed and evangelical writers reject open theism, but treat open theists as misguided fellow Christians rather than as a cult. Process theology, by contrast, denies classical immutability outright and is generally judged outside historic Christianity. The clearest public-record denials are Mormonism, which teaches a God who progressed from manhood and continues to progress, and Christian Science under Mary Baker Eddy, which redefines God so radically that the historic attributes drop away. On the bare proposition that God's being, character, purposes, and promises do not change, historic Christianity speaks with one voice.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	Yes
Cult marker if denied	No
Would visit if otherwise	Yes
Would participate if otherwise	No
Would serve if otherwise	No
Would be member if otherwise	No
Would let children be taught otherwise	No
Would marry if held otherwise	No
Would publicly correct if otherwise	Yes

Notes

Immutability holds canonically when 'immutability' is read as the historic doctrine intends it: God does not change in his essence, character, knowledge, will, or covenantal commitments. Scripture itself surfaces the tension by juxtaposing 1 Sam 15:11 ('I regret making Saul king', nacham niphal) with 1 Sam 15:29 ('the Glory of Israel will not lie or have regret', same nacham lemma negated, with the explicit reason that God is not a man). This juxtaposition is canonical instruction to the reader to read one set of texts as accommodation. Jeremiah 18:7-10 makes the conditional principle explicit: announced judgment is conditional on the nation's response, and the announced 'relenting' is the principled outworking of God's unchanging character, not change in him. Public-record carriers of explicit denial: open theists (Clark Pinnock, Gregory Boyd, John Sanders, Richard Rice) read the nacham passages literally and deny strong immutability of will and knowledge; they remain in-house evangelical disputants, not a cult. Process theology (Whitehead, Hartshorne, Cobb) denies classical immutability fully and places its adherents

outside historic Christianity on this point. Mormonism rejects classical attributes entirely and teaches a God who progressed and continues to progress, a clean denial. Cult-marker line: denial of immutability of essence and character (a god who lies, breaks covenant, can become unholy) crosses into denial of the God of Scripture; denial of strong impassibility or denial of strong foreknowledge does not. The cult-marker bar is therefore set higher than mere disagreement with classical immutability and is met by Mormon and process-theology denials but not by open theism. `would_die_for=true`: the covenant-keeping God is the God of Scripture; a god who could become other than he is is not.

Stem audit

`verdict-preloaded: no`

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. `classical_theism`, `open_theism`, `process_theology`

`analogia scripturae` invoked

Competing lens verdicts

- **affirms:**
- **complicates:**
- **denies:**

The verdict rests on a small but lexically uncontested set of canonical anchors: `shanah` H8138 (negated of God in Mal 3:6), `nacham` H5162 (negated of God in Num 23:19 `hitpael` and 1 Sam 15:29 `niphal`), `parallage` G3883 (negated of God in Jas 1:17), `autos` G846 (predicated of Christ in Heb 13:8), and `ametathetos` G276 (predicated of God's purpose and the divine yes in Heb 6:17-18). `Analogia scripturae` is essential here. The same `nacham` H5162 lemma is affirmed of God in roughly seven passages (Gen 6:6, 6:7, Ex 32:14, 1 Sam 15:11, 15:35, Jonah 3:10, Jer 18:8 first-person) and negated of God in two (Num 23:19, 1 Sam 15:29). The canon itself supplies the resolution: 1 Sam 15:29 explicitly distinguishes the divine 'not regretting' from human regret on the basis that God 'is not a man', and Jer 18:7-10 supplies the conditional principle that turns the affirmative uses into the announced outworking of God's unchanging character rather than into changes in him. This is the accommodation hermeneutic, rooted in Hilary of Poitiers and developed by Calvin. Without accommodation, the canon contradicts itself within a single chapter (1 Sam 15). The verdict therefore holds canonically, but with the explicit recognition that the accommodation hermeneutic is required. Frameworks producing different verdicts: open theism and process theology, the former in-house and the latter outside historic Christianity

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

Mal.3.6 · **for** · genre: prophecy

Key term. `יִתְיַבֵּשׁ אֱלֹהִים`; `shanah` H8138 `qal perfect 1cs negated`

Force. `shanah` = to change, alter, repeat, transform. `Qal perfect first person common singular, negated`: 'I the LORD have not changed'. First-person divine speech. The covenantal ground of Israel's preservation in the very next clause ('therefore you, O sons of Jacob, are not consumed') is the unchangedness of God himself

Num.23.19 · for · genre: narrative

Key term. נָחַם; nacham H5162 hitpael imperfect 3ms

Force. nacham hitpael = to change one's mind, repent reflexively. 'God is not man, that he should lie, or a son of man, that he should change his mind'. Balaam's third oracle. The denial is categorical: God is essentially unlike man precisely in the matter of repenting or going back on his word. The same lemma as the niph'al in Gen 6:6 and 1 Sam 15:11, here flatly denied of God

1Sam.15.29 · for · genre: narrative · figures: anthropopathism

Key term. נָחַם; nacham H5162 niph'al imperfect 3ms; שָׁקַר H8266; netsach H5331

Force. 'And also the Glory of Israel will not lie or have regret, for he is not a man, that he should have regret'. The verse pairs the verb 'lie' (shaqar) with 'have regret' (nacham niph'al) and negates both of God on the basis of his non-manhood. Sits in the same chapter as v.11 where the same nacham lemma is affirmed of God. The canon's own self-resolution: one of the two readings must be accommodation, and the explicit reason given here ('he is not a man') points to v.11 as the accommodation

Jas.1.17 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key term. παρ' ᾧ οὐκ ἔνι παραλλαγή ἢ τροπή ἀποσκίασμα; parallage G3883; trope G5157; aposkiasma G644

Force. parallage = variation, change (astronomical: parallax, apparent shift in heavenly bodies); trope = a turning, rotation (the same root used for the solstice 'turning' of the sun); aposkiasma = shadow. Hapax legomenon of parallage in the NT. The Father of lights, unlike the lights themselves, has no parallax and no rotational shadow. The metaphor is precise: the celestial bodies God made do change in apparent position and cast moving shadows; God does not

Heb.13.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. Ἰησοῦς Χριστὸς ἐχθὲς καὶ σήμερον ὁ αὐτὸς καὶ εἰς τοὺς αἰῶνας; autos G846

Force. autos = the same, the very one. Predicate nominative with the definite article, the strongest Greek formulation for identity across time. 'Jesus Christ the same yesterday and today and forever'. Applies the divine attribute of immutability to the incarnate Son directly. The temporal trio (chthes, semeron, eis tous aionas) spans the totality of time

Heb.6.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. τὸ ἀμετάθετον τῆς βουλῆς αὐτοῦ; ametathetos G276; boule G1012

Force. ametathetos = not transposable, unchangeable, immutable. Adjective accusative neuter singular used substantively: 'the unchangeable character of his purpose'. boule = counsel, deliberate purpose. God confirms the unchangeable purpose by oath. The point of vv.17-18 is the impossibility of God lying combined with the unchangeable purpose, giving 'two unchangeable things' (v.18: dyo pragmaton ametatheton) as the ground of believers' assurance

Heb.6.18 · for · genre: epistle

Key term. δύο πραγμάτων ἀμεταθέτων; ametathetos G276 plural; pseudomai G5574

Force. 'Two unchangeable things, in which it is impossible for God to lie'. The same ametathetos G276 lemma in the plural. The two unchangeables are the promise and the oath. The argument grounds Christian hope in the impossibility of divine change, including the impossibility of God being false to his word

Ps.102.27 · for · genre: psalm

Key term. וְנִמְתִּי אֶל־רִיבֹנִי אוֹהֵב־הֵתֵאָוּ hu H1931

Force. 'But you are the same, and your years have no end'. Quoted at Heb 1:12 of the Son. Concordance reinforcement: same theological substance as Heb 13:8 (autos) and Mal 3:6 (shanah negated), here in the Psalter as the prayer of the afflicted. The 'you are the same' (atah hu) language is grammatically the closest Hebrew parallel to the Greek autos predicate of Heb 13:8

Gen.6.6 · complicates · genre: narrative · figures: anthropomorphism, anthropopathism

Key term. נָחַם ה' הוּאִי כְחָנִי; nacham H5162 niphil consecutive imperfect 3ms; atsab H6087 hitpael

Force. nacham niphil = to be sorry, regret, relent. atsab hitpael = to be grieved, pained. 'The LORD regretted that he had made humanity on the earth, and it grieved him to his heart'. Read literally, suggests God repents of past action, which would complicate immutability. Read as accommodation (per Num 23:19 and 1 Sam 15:29), describes divine grief over creaturely sin in human terms while God's eternal purpose continues unchanged through Noah

Exod.32.14 · complicates · genre: narrative · figures: anthropomorphism, anthropopathism

Key term. נָחַם ה' הוּאִי כְחָנִי; nacham H5162 niphil consecutive imperfect 3ms

Force. 'The LORD relented from the disaster he had threatened to do to his people'. After Moses' intercession at the golden calf. Read literally, God changes course. Read as accommodation, God's announced judgment was conditional on intercession and repentance, and Moses' intercession was itself part of the unchanging plan; the verse describes the historical outworking of God's unchanging covenantal mercy

1Sam.15.11 · complicates · genre: narrative · figures: anthropopathism

Key term. נָחַם ה' לֹא־שָׂתָא יִתְכַלְמֶה־יֵכ יִתְמַחַנּוּ; nacham H5162 niphil perfect 1cs

Force. 'I regret that I have made Saul king'. First-person divine speech of regret. Same lemma both affirmed of God here in v.11 and denied of God in v.29 of the same chapter. The chapter itself instructs the reader to hold one of the two as accommodation; v.29 gives the reason ('he is not a man'), which pushes v.11 toward the anthropopathic side

Jonah.3.10 · complicates · genre: prophecy · figures: anthropopathism

Key term. נָחַם ה' הוּאִי כְחָנִי; nacham H5162 niphil consecutive imperfect 3ms

Force. 'God relented of the disaster that he had said he would do to them, and he did not do it'. Nineveh's repentance is the antecedent. Read alongside Jer 18:7-10 (the principle of conditional prophecy), this is the announced principle of how God relates to repenting nations, not a change in the divine mind or character. The 'relenting' is the predicted outworking of God's unchanging mercy

Jer.18.8 · complicates · genre: prophecy · figures: anthropopathism

Key term. נָחַם ה' הוּאִי כְחָנִי; nacham H5162 niphil conjunctive perfect 1cs

Force. 'If that nation, concerning which I have spoken, turns from its evil, I will relent of the disaster that I intended to do to it'. God himself states the conditional principle in the first person. Divine 'relenting' is the announced response to creaturely repentance, built into the prophetic word from the start. This text supplies the canon's own hermeneutical key for reading Gen 6:6, Ex 32:14, 1 Sam 15:11, and Jonah 3:10

Titus.1.2 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. ὁ ἀψευδὴς θεός; apseudes G893

Force. apseudes = not lying, truthful, incapable of falsehood. 'God, who never lies, promised before the ages began'. Anchors the immutability of God's word in the immutability of his nature. The God who cannot lie cannot break his word, and the God who cannot break his word cannot fail his promises

2Tim.2.13 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key term. ἀρνήσασθαι γὰρ ἑαυτὸν οὐ δύναται; arneomai G720; dynamai G1410

Force. 'If we are faithless, he remains faithful, for he cannot deny himself'. The classical limit and the classical guarantee: God cannot act against his own being. Directly grounds the immutability of God's character and covenantal faithfulness in the immutability of his being

Concordance lemmas traversed

H8138, H5162, H8266, H5331, H6087, H1931, G3883, G5157, G644, G846, G276, G1012, G5574, G893, G720, G1410

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

patristic · Thomas Aquinas, Summa Theologica Part I, Question 9, Article 1, 'Whether God is altogether immutable' (CCEL) · affirms · verified

"Aquinas: 'God is altogether immutable'. Three arguments: God is pure act (no potency to change), absolutely simple (no composition to be altered), and infinitely perfect (nothing new to acquire). Cites Mal 3:6 directly"

catholic_magisterial · Catechism of the Catholic Church, paragraphs 202-213 on the divine name 'I AM', and the historic confession of God as 'eternal and unchangeable' · affirms · unverified

"The Catechism teaches the eternity and unchangeable being of God grounded in the divine name revealed at Ex 3:14. Catholic dogmatic tradition (e.g., Lateran IV) confesses God as 'incommutabilis' (unchangeable)"

lutheran · Augsburg Confession Article I, Of God (bookofconcord.org) · affirms · unverified

"One Divine Essence, eternal, without body, without parts, of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness, the Maker and Preserver of all things'. The eternal, simple, infinite God of Lutheran confession is immutable in the historic sense"

anglican · 39 Articles, Article I, Of Faith in the Holy Trinity (Church of England) · affirms · unverified

"There is but one living and true God, everlasting, without body, parts, or passions; of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness'. The classical phrase 'without parts or passions' historically encodes immutability and impassibility"

reformed · Westminster Confession of Faith 2.1; 1689 Baptist Confession 2.1 · affirms · unverified

"Westminster 2.1: 'There is but one only living and true God, who is infinite in being and perfection, a most pure spirit, invisible, without body, parts, or passions, immutable, immense, eternal, incomprehensible, almighty'. Immutable named directly"

methodist · United Methodist Articles of Religion, Article I, Of Faith in the Holy Trinity (umc.org) · affirms · verified

“There is but one living and true God, everlasting, without body or parts, of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness; the maker and preserver of all things'. Wesley's abridgement of the 39 Articles, retains the immutability substance”

anabaptist · Dordrecht Confession of Faith (1632), Article 1, Of God and the Creation of All Things · affirms · unverified

“We believe in one eternal, almighty, and incomprehensible God, Father, Son, and Holy Ghost'. The eternal almighty God of the Anabaptist tradition is the immutable God of historic Christianity”

pentecostal · Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths, Truth 2, The One True God (ag.org) · affirms · unverified

“The one true God has revealed Himself as the eternally self-existent I AM, the Creator of heaven and earth and the Redeemer of mankind'. Eternal self-existence is the metaphysical ground of immutability”

eastern_orthodox · OCA, The Orthodox Faith, on God the Father (oca.org), citing the Liturgy of St. John Chrysostom · affirms · verified

“God, ineffable, inconceivable, invisible, incomprehensible, ever-existing and eternally the same'. The liturgical phrase 'eternally the same' is the Orthodox confession of divine immutability”

continuationist · Open theist authors Clark Pinnock, Most Moved Mover (2001); Gregory Boyd, God of the Possible (2000); John Sanders, The God Who Risks (1998) · complicates · unverified

“Open theism affirms God's character, love, and saving purpose as unchanging, but denies strong immutability of will and knowledge with respect to genuinely free creaturely futures. Reads the nacham texts as real divine responsiveness”

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/malachi/3-6.htm>

“Mal 3:6 shanah H8138 qal perfect 1cs negated: 'I the LORD have not changed'. First-person divine self-statement. The ground of Israel's preservation is the unchangedness of God”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/numbers/23-19.htm>

“Num 23:19 nacham H5162 hitpa'el imperfect 3ms: 'son of man, that he should change his mind'. Categorical denial of repentance / mind-change of God on the basis of his non-manhooood”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/1_samuel/15-29.htm

“1 Sam 15:29 nacham H5162 niphal (twice) negated of God: 'the Glory of Israel will not lie or have regret, for he is not a man, that he should have regret'. Same lemma affirmed of God in v.11 of same chapter”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/james/1-17.htm>

“Jas 1:17 parallage G3883 (astronomical parallax, hapax in NT) and trope G5157 (turning, solstice) negated of the Father of lights: 'no variation or shadow due to change”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/hebrews/13-8.htm>

“Heb 13:8 autos G846 with the definite article, predicate nominative: 'Jesus Christ the same yesterday and today and forever'. Divine immutability predicated of the incarnate Son”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/hebrews/6-17.htm>

“Heb 6:17 ametathetos G276 substantival: 'the unchangeable character of his purpose'. v.18 plural ametatheton with two pragmaton: 'two unchangeable things, in which it is impossible for God to lie”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongs/hebrew/8138.htm>

“shanah H8138 = to change, alter, repeat, transform. 22 OT occurrences. Mal 3:6 is the explicit denial of change predicated of God in the first person”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongs/hebrew/5162.htm>

“nacham H5162 niphal = to be sorry, repent, relent. Used of God affirmatively at Gen 6:6, 6:7, Ex 32:14, 1 Sam 15:11, 15:35, Jonah 3:10, Jer 18:8 (1cs). Negated of God at Num 23:19 and 1 Sam 15:29”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strongs/greek/3883.htm>

“parallage G3883 = variation, change. Astronomical: the apparent shift in position of heavenly bodies. NT hapax at Jas 1:17. The Father of lights, unlike the lights he made, has no parallax”

supports · category: patristic_archive · https://ccel.org/ccel/aquinas/summa/summa.FP_Q9_A1.html

“Aquinas, Summa I Q.9 A.1: 'God is altogether immutable'. Cites Mal 3:6 ('I am the Lord, and I change not'). Three arguments: pure act, absolute simplicity, infinite perfection. The 'God relented' texts read as accommodation”

supports · category: tradition_primary ·

<https://www.oca.org/orthodoxy/the-orthodox-faith/doctrine-scripture/the-symbol-of-faith/god>

“OCA, citing the Liturgy of St. John Chrysostom: God is 'ever-existing and eternally the same'. The Orthodox liturgical confession of divine immutability”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.umc.org/en/content/articles-of-religion>

“UMC Article I: 'There is but one living and true God, everlasting, without body or parts, of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness'. Methodist confession of the eternal, infinite, unchanging God”

Flags

- accommodation-hermeneutic-required